

Basanite GSTACK Analysis & Next Steps

The Six Forcing Questions

There are the **Six Forcing Questions** from gstack's office-hours skill, which are the core diagnostic framework Garry Tan encoded from years of YC partner sessions. Each one targets a specific way founders fool themselves.

Q1: Demand Reality

Do people actually want this, or just find it interesting? There's a huge gap between "that's a cool idea" and "I would be genuinely upset if this disappeared tomorrow." Waitlists, positive feedback, and investor excitement don't count. Behavior counts, someone paying, someone building their workflow around it, someone panicking when it breaks.

Q2: Status Quo

What are people doing right now to solve this problem, even badly? Every real problem has a workaround. Understanding the workaround tells you what you're actually competing against (usually spreadsheets and Slack, not another startup), and forces you to quantify the real cost of the pain you're solving.

Q3: Desperate Specificity

Who is the single most desperate human being for this product? Not a market segment, not a persona, a named person with a title, a specific consequence they face if this problem isn't solved, and ideally something you heard directly from their mouth. "Enterprises in healthcare" is not a customer. You can't call a market segment at 9pm.

Q4: Narrowest Wedge

What is the absolute smallest version of this that someone would pay real money for this week? Not after you build the platform. Not the full vision. The one feature, the one workflow, the one thing you could ship in days that has standalone value. Most founders are attached to building the full thing before anyone can use it, this question forces them off that.

Q5: Observation & Surprise

Have you actually sat and watched someone use this without helping them? Not a demo, not a survey, but silent observation. The question isn't just "have you done user research," it's specifically "what surprised you?" If nothing has surprised you, you either haven't watched

closely enough or you're filtering what you see through your own assumptions. Real usage always contradicts the founder's mental model somewhere.

Q6: Future-Fit

In 3 years, when the world looks meaningfully different, does your product become more essential or less? This isn't asking for a market size projection. It's asking for your specific thesis about how your users' world changes and why that change makes you more valuable, not a rising tide argument that every competitor can also make.

The reason they're called "forcing" questions is structural: each one is designed so that vague, optimistic, or framework-level answers don't pass. Every question has a specific failure mode it's hunting for, and a specific type of evidence that would actually satisfy it.

Our Current Gap & Action Plans

Based on the diagnostic, Basanite has three specific network gaps

Gap 1: No practitioners (Q1 + Q3 failures)

You need people who hire technical talent at volume, right now. Not as advisors but as early pilots.

Potential networks we can access to mend this gap:

1. Silicon Drinkabout

- Silicon Drinkabout is a global, volunteer-run weekly meetup for the startup and tech community, originally founded in London in 2011 and now running in dozens of cities worldwide. It happens every Friday at a rotating venue, requires no sign-up, and costs nothing to attend. It is simply a reliable gathering point for founders, engineers, product managers, recruiters, and investors who are embedded in the local tech scene. Its value is not in the quantity of attendees but in the regularity, the same people show up week after week, which means relationships compound over time. In the context of talent communities specifically, **Heads of Talent and technical recruiters at growth-stage startups are regular attendees**, particularly at the London events around Shoreditch and Old Street.
- Action plan:
 - Attend London Silicon Drinkabout consistently for six consecutive weeks. Do not go once and expect results.
 - Make the goal of the first two or three visits purely conversational. Ask about the other person's company, their role, their current hiring challenges. Do not introduce Basanite until the problem has been named by the other person.

2. People Geek

- People Geek is a Slack-based community of over 15,000 HR leaders and talent professionals, run by CultureAmp. It is focused specifically on data-driven, evidence-based approaches to HR. Members are, by self-selection, the practitioners who are most likely to be frustrated with legacy tools and most open to experimenting with new approaches. The community runs virtual events, webinars, and working groups, and has a strict code of conduct against vendor pitching, which means the conversations are genuine.
- Action plan:
 - Join People Geek via the CultureAmp onboarding form and complete the full onboarding.
 - Read the community guidelines carefully, any hint of vendor positioning gets members removed!
 - Get insights about assessment design, share the academic research that underpins Basanite's methodology, and engage with what others are saying about AI in hiring. Build a reputation as a practitioner who knows the subject, not as a vendor.
 - Identify five to ten members whose LinkedIn profiles suggest they are actively hiring technical talent at volume and whose posts signal frustration with existing tools. Connect with them on LinkedIn, engage with their content genuinely, and when the time is right, approach them as a potential design partner and not a customer.
 - Once Basanite has one or two design partner outcomes worth sharing, post about them in the community in the spirit of open-source knowledge sharing: here is what we tried, here is what we measured, here is what we learned. This is the native language of People Geek and will generate far more engagement than a product announcement.
 - Also join the Amplify Talent Community (amplifytalent.com) and engage with Lars Schmidt's content directly on LinkedIn. Schmidt is a connector; getting him interested in the methodology is a force-multiplier into his extended network of progressive talent leaders.

3. Recruiting Brainfood

- Recruiting Brainfood is a once-a-week, manually curated newsletter trusted by over 30,000 recruiters and HR professionals worldwide, edited by Hung Lee. It is the most concentrated and respected source of talent industry intelligence in Europe and arguably globally. Hung curates content from non-mainstream sources including academic research, practitioner experiments and contrarian takes, rather than press releases and vendor content. Its mission is to help recruiters and HR professionals get better by sharing great recruiting and HR content from lesser-known sources. Beyond the newsletter, Hung runs Brainfood Live, a regular series of online conversations with practitioners and researchers on specific topics in recruiting and assessment. The community aspect extends to a paid online community where the most engaged subscribers discuss the content, share their own experiments, and surface emerging practices.

Hung's personal credibility is such that being featured or discussed in Brainfood functions as a peer endorsement within the talent community.

- Action Plan:
 - Subscribe to Recruiting Brainfood and read every issue before attempting any outreach. Understand the editorial sensibility: what Hung finds interesting, what kinds of research he features, what framing he responds to. Do not pitch until you can speak the publication's language.
 - Identify a genuine piece of intellectual content that Brainfood would want to feature independently of any Basanite association. A structured write-up of the assessment methodology, a commissioned piece of original research on how AI-era hiring differs from conventional models, or a candid account of a design partner experiment with real data, any of these would fit the editorial.
 - Reach out to Hung directly on LinkedIn, not with a pitch but with a substantive response to something he has written. The goal is to enter his orbit as a practitioner who is doing interesting work, not as a vendor seeking coverage.
 - Once a relationship is established, propose a Brainfood Live session on a topic that is genuinely interesting to the community — something like "what assessment actually predicts performance in AI-era technical roles" — and offer to bring academic voices from Basanite's research partnerships to the conversation. This is the format that generates the most community engagement and the most durable credibility.
 - If a design partner outcome is strong and the partner is willing to be referenced publicly, a short case note in Brainfood's open-source style could become one of the most effective pieces of marketing content Basanite produces.
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Gap 2: No validation data (Q6 moat concern)

The technique inventory is plaintext. The durable moat is predictive validity: proof that Basanite scores predict actual job performance. That requires academic partnerships.

1. Loughborough / Warwick / UCL psychology departments

- All three universities house active industrial-organisational (I-O) psychology research groups whose work centres on exactly the problem Basanite is trying to solve: what assessment instruments actually predict job performance, how bias enters evaluation processes, and how to design structured assessments that are both valid and fair. These departments do not just study hiring in the

abstract, they conduct field research in partnership with employers, which means they have both the methodology and the relationships to generate the kind of predictive validity data that would make Basanite's claims defensible.

- Action Plan:
 - Identify the specific research leads at each department whose published work is most closely aligned with Basanite's methodology. Search Google Scholar for recent publications on structured interview validity, AI-assisted assessment, and hiring bias from each institution. The goal is to approach the right person, not the department administrator.
 - Draft a one-page research proposal that frames the partnership as a genuine academic contribution, not a commercial validation exercise. The offer is simple: Basanite provides anonymised assessment data and outcome tracking (did candidates who scored well on Basanite perform well in the role?), and the academic partner designs the study, owns the analysis, and publishes the findings. Basanite gets the right to cite the published research.
 - Approach UCL first given its London proximity and strong I-O psychology programme, and frame the initial conversation as exploratory: what would a valid study of this kind look like, and would the department be interested in collaborating?
 - Accept that this is a 12 to 18 month process to generate publishable results. The investor-facing signal is the partnership itself, not the findings. Announce the research collaboration publicly once it is formalised.
 - Build the data infrastructure within the product now to make this tractable: structured outcome tracking at the role level, anonymisation pipelines, and the ability to link assessment scores to hirer-reported performance signals at 3, 6, and 12 months post-hire.

2. SIOP (Society for Industrial-Organisational Psychology)

- SIOP is the premier professional association for industrial-organisational psychology, with over 9,000 members practicing all over the world. It is the academic community that sets the standards for what counts as valid, reliable, and fair assessment in the workplace. SIOP members publish the research that HR practitioners eventually cite, sit on the expert panels that advise regulators on hiring fairness, and consult to the enterprise companies that eventually become Basanite's Tier 1 customers. SIOP also runs an annual conference that is the most important gathering point for I-O psychology researchers and practitioners globally, and the 41st Annual SIOP Conference is scheduled for April 29 to May 2, 2026, in New Orleans.
- Action Plan:
 - Join SIOP as an Affiliate member, which is open to organisations with an interest in I-O science even without a doctoral degree in the field. The Affiliate track is the appropriate entry point for a startup.

- Identify two or three SIOP Fellows whose published work overlaps most closely with Basanite's assessment framework and request a conversation, not to pitch the product, but to ask for their honest methodological critique. Researchers respond far better to intellectual engagement than to commercial approaches.
- If the conversations go well, explore whether any SIOP-connected researchers would be willing to serve on an advisory board or contribute to the research partnership programme described above. A named SIOP Fellow on Basanite's advisory board is a credential that carries weight with both enterprise buyers and investors.

3. Behavioural Insights Team (BIT)

- The Behavioural Insights Team, known unofficially as the "Nudge Unit", is a UK-based global social purpose organisation that generates and applies behavioural insights to inform policy and improve public services. Originally set up inside the UK Cabinet Office in 2010, it is now fully owned by the charity Nesta and works with governments, employers, and non-profits globally. Critically for Basanite, BIT partners with employers and governments to apply behavioural insights and create evidence-based approaches that strengthen labour markets and improve jobs and workplaces, including specific work on improving recruitment, reducing hiring bias, and validating assessment instruments. BIT also spun out Applied, a hiring platform that uses behavioural science to replace CV-based screening, making BIT one of the few organisations in the world with both the academic credibility and the practical hiring experience to engage with Basanite as a genuine intellectual peer.
- Action Plan:
 - Read BIT's published reports on hiring and assessment before making contact. Engage with the arguments in it deeply enough to have a genuine intellectual conversation about where Basanite's methodology agrees with, extends, or differs from BIT's findings.
 - Identify the BIT team members who work specifically on jobs and hiring (the Economy / Jobs & Work team). Approach them via LinkedIn with a substantive engagement about the research, not a commercial pitch.
 - The most viable collaboration framing is a joint exploration of AI-era assessment validity: what does the behavioural science literature say about which human capabilities remain irreplaceable as AI handles more execution tasks, and how should assessment instruments be redesigned around those capabilities? This is a question BIT has genuine intellectual interest in, and it is Basanite's core thesis.
 - Explore whether BIT would be willing to design or co-design a validation study using Basanite's assessment data. BIT's methodological rigour, particularly their use of randomised controlled trials, would make any validation study they were involved in essentially unassailable by critics.

- **Do not position Basanite as a competitor to Applied.** Frame it as a different design philosophy addressing the same root problem from a different direction. The conversation is more productive and the relationship is more durable if it begins from genuine intellectual respect rather than competitive positioning.
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Gap 3: No path to YC (the stated goal)

YC funds traction, not decks. Getting into YC's orbit before having the right traction signals is possible, but it requires using the right on-ramps. The three routes suggested each serve a distinct purpose.

1. YC Startup School

- YC Startup School is a free resource for early-stage founders, offering advice based on 15 years of YC's knowledge, accountability tools for weekly progress, and co-founder matching. It runs as a self-paced online course covering everything from idea validation to fundraising, taught by YC partners and alumni. Importantly, it is not just content — it includes assignment to an advisor from the YC alumni network, access to a large active founder community, and crucially, a direct application track into YC itself. Completing Startup School and demonstrating meaningful weekly progress is one of the most effective signals that a team is already building with YC-like rigour.
- Action Plan:
 - Enrol in YC Startup School immediately via startupschool.org. Select the active founder track, not the aspiring founder track. The advisor assignment and weekly accountability structure require being on the founder track.
 - Submit genuine, specific weekly updates. YC partners read these. Updates that show real customer conversations, real design partner progress, and real metric movement are the ones that get attention. Do not submit vague updates.
 - Engage actively in the community forum. Answer other founders' questions in areas where Basanite has relevant expertise: hiring, assessment, B2B sales in HR tech. Being a generous contributor raises your profile within the community.
 - When assigned an advisor, prepare for the meetings with specific, honest questions about the challenges you are actually facing. The advisor relationship is wasted if it becomes a status update call rather than a genuine working session.
 - Use the co-founder matching platform if needed. YC's matching database is now one of the largest in the world. If Basanite's founding team has gaps, particularly in technical depth or enterprise sales experience, this is the right place to address them

before applying.

2. Entrepreneur First (EF)

- Entrepreneur First was founded in 2011 and works with individuals rather than companies, finding and investing in individuals with the potential to become founders, often before they have a cofounder or idea. EF has helped create more than 600 companies with a combined value of over \$11 billion as of 2025. The programme runs in two phases: Form (12 weeks in London, focused on finding a cofounder and developing an idea) and Launch (12 weeks in San Francisco, focused on building traction and raising a seed round). Companies that pitch at EF's San Francisco Demo Day typically raise between \$1–7M within a couple of weeks, with investors including Founders Fund, Sequoia, a16z, and Index Ventures. Critically, EF's model differs from YC in that it invests in individuals, not companies. This makes it the right vehicle if Basanite's founding team wants to strengthen its composition before a YC application, bringing in a technical co-founder, a domain expert in I-O psychology, or a seasoned enterprise sales operator.
- Action plan
 - Assess honestly whether the founding team has the composition it needs. If there is a gap, most commonly, either deep technical depth in AI/ML assessment systems or enterprise sales experience in HR tech, apply to EF as an individual to find the right co-founder rather than trying to fill the gap with an early hire.
 - If the founding team is complete, approach EF differently: as a partner network rather than a programme. EF alumni are among the most accessible and genuinely helpful founder communities in Europe. Attend EF events (they run regular hackathons, build retreats, and AI startup school events that are open to non-programme participants) and build relationships within the alumni network.
 - Specifically target EF portfolio companies as design partners. These are companies that are building fast, hiring engineers at volume, and typically do not yet have a mature TA function. They are predisposed to trying new tools and, if they have a positive experience, will talk about it within the EF community, which functions as a highly trusted peer network.
 - If applying to EF formally, frame the "Domain Edge" as the primary qualification: years of direct experience and insight into what is broken in technical hiring, with a clear thesis for how it can be fixed. EF explicitly values domain expertise as a founding advantage.
 - Treat the Demo Day investor list as an intelligence asset. EF Demo Days have featured opening fireside chats with Patrick Collison (Stripe), Vinod Khosla, and Jack Clark (Anthropic). Understanding which investors are paying attention to EF's pipeline helps Basanite understand who to build relationships with before a formal raise.

3. Work Trial / Pallet

- Work Trial and Pallet are both community-driven platforms that sit at the intersection of hiring and community. Pallet is a tool that lets communities and newsletters run their own job boards, it powers hiring for hundreds of tech communities and creator newsletters, meaning the companies posting roles on Pallet are often smaller, community-embedded organisations that hire in exactly the way Basanite's product addresses. Work Trial refers to the broader practice of hiring through work samples and trials rather than traditional interviews, a practice that is philosophically adjacent to Basanite's rejection of interview preparedness as a valid signal. The relevance for Basanite is not primarily as a community to join, but as an environment where the pain Basanite solves is felt most acutely and discussed most candidly. Companies using Pallet for hiring are dealing with the same screening volume problem in a context where they have minimal infrastructure to handle it. They are natural early adopters and, if they become satisfied design partners, they talk about it publicly within their newsletter communities — which is exactly the kind of word-of-mouth that reaches YC partners.
 - Action plan
 - Identify five to ten companies currently using Pallet for their engineering hiring. These are accessible through the public Pallet job boards. Contact the hiring managers directly with a design partner offer. The framing should be around the problem (screening volume with no dedicated TA function) rather than the product.
 - Engage with the Work Trial community and content on LinkedIn and Twitter. Practitioners who advocate for work-sample-based hiring are already philosophically aligned with Basanite's core thesis. Building relationships with them generates both design partner candidates and credible public advocates.
 - When preparing a YC application, include any Pallet-sourced design partners explicitly. YC values traction in communities that are hard to reach through conventional sales, a design partner who came through a newsletter community rather than through outbound sales signals that the product has genuine word-of-mouth pull.
 - Consider reaching out to Pallet itself about a partnership or integration. If Basanite's assessment can be triggered directly from a Pallet job posting, the distribution problem becomes substantially smaller.
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The sequencing matters.

Don't pursue all of these at once. The diagnostic says **the most urgent gap is Q3**, finding one named person with a specific problem. Recruiting Brainfood gets you there fastest. Everything else follows from having a real customer to talk about.